

SOLBECK HOUSE
Indiana Dunes National Park
3037 Dabbert Drive
Porter
Porter County
Indiana

HABS IN-319
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WRITTEN HISTORICAL AND DESCRIPTIVE DATA

REDUCED COPIES OF MEASURED DRAWINGS

FIELD RECORDS

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY
National Park Service
U.S. Department of the Interior
1849 C Street NW
Washington, DC 20240

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY

SOLBECK HOUSE

HABS No. IN-319

Location: Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore, Tract 03-165, Porter Beach, Dabbert Drive, Porter County, Porter, Indiana 46304. Section 14, Township 37 N, Range 6 W; Lots 10, 11, 12, and 13 in Block 7 in the Lake Shore Addition to the New Stockyards, Town of Porter. The site consists of lots ten, eleven, twelve, and thirteen in block seven in the Lake Shore Addition to the New Stockyards, in the town of Potter, Indiana. The site measures one hundred by one hundred feet, containing approximately 2.3 acres of land.¹

Present Owner: National Park Service, U.S. Department of the Interior

Present Occupant: National Park Service, U.S. Department of the Interior

Present Use: Vacant

Significance: Built ca. 1930, the Solbeck site, including the house and landscape, is significant for its association with patterns of historical development and distinctive design characteristics indicative of the region. It was built as a vacation cottage along the lake shore in the area known as Porter Beach, a resort development that flourished during the 1920s and 1930s. The house is an excellent example of the Craftsman-influenced, vernacular beach property that was common in the Indiana Dunes during that period, but that has rarely survived in an unaltered state. The modest, vernacular cottages built at Porter Beach are similar to many of the pre-World War II cottages built in and around the cities of Gary and Michigan City, Indiana. By contrast, most of the houses built in the nearby communities of Dune Acres and Beverly Shores are more substantial and stylish. There are few if any of this type of property extant in the Indiana Dunes that compare to the Solbeck site for integrity of both structure and landscape setting. It was used as a beach cottage until 1952.

Description: The Solbeck site is located on top of a sand dune in the Porter Beach residential development of the Town of Porter. The landscape character at the site is one of a secluded woodland hideaway nestled into the steep sand dunes. Built ca. 1930, the Solbeck House is of frame construction and has an irregular plan consisting of a one-and-one-half story gabled front main block nearly square in plan, a shed roof wing, and a small gabled roof rear ell. The wing, located on the north side, was an early

¹ Information regarding the size of the property is from a document titled "Site Description," located in the tract file at Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore.

addition by the original builders of the house.² Structural evidence suggests that the rear ell may have been an early addition. The house was built on a foundation of wood and concrete block piers, although vertical wood plank skirting concealed much of it. The remainder of the house is clad in wood shiplap siding. There is an entrance door on the front (east facade) of the house. Pressure treated wood steps led to a small stoop with a simple board railing. The metal door is a later replacement.

The windows on the main block of the house are awning windows of the distinctive five pane design found elsewhere in Porter Beach.³ Windows on the wing addition are three-over-one-light, double hung sash, with one horizontal multi-pane window on the lower level. The rear ell has one multi-pane casement window. All of the windows are wood, and a number of them have solid headboard shutters. The house has exposed rafter tails, an asphalt shingle roof, and a brick chimney toward the rear of the main block. It is painted white with brown trim.

The house contains 712 square feet of living space on the main level plus a bathroom on the lower level. The remainder of the lower level is unfinished and used for storage space. The main floor of the house is dominated by one large open room that contains twin beds lining the exterior walls, a dining table with chairs in the center of the room, and a wood-burning heating stove. The studs, siding, and rafters were all visible on the interior.⁴

Prior to September 2012 when the house was vacated, it was in good condition, and had an unusually high level of integrity. According to Joan Solbeck, a former owner, the only change that her family made to the house subsequent to purchasing it in the 1960s was to add indoor plumbing in the 1980s. Before then there had been a pump at the kitchen sink, and a chemical toilet. A comparison of the house from 2010 and photographs taken in 1975 showed very little change to the exterior. The front steps and railing had been rebuilt in a slightly different configuration, the front door had been replaced, and vertical skirting had replaced some of the shiplap siding. If there had been other changes to the exterior of the house since the 1930s they were minor. However, since then the house has been heavily vandalized.

Landscape: The Solbeck site (Tract #03-165) is nestled in a dune located to the north of Tract #03-162, the Rechord site (see figure 1). There is no vehicular

² Per Joan Solbeck and supported by structural evidence.

³ Because some of the windows were covered by shutters during the original inspection of the site, it was possible that some of the windows were a different style.

⁴ That description is based on a tour taken of the interior of the house by staff members from Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore in the 1990s.

access to the site and parking for it is located at the northern terminus of Dabbert Drive, adjacent to the Rechord site. From that point the site is approached on foot. A sand trail leads up the dune traveling east and then north along the fence demarking the boundary between the national lakeshore and Indiana Dunes State Park. A portion of the trail is very steep and chunks of concrete and wood railroad ties situated to provide crude steps. A rope railing was adjacent to the steps. At the top of the trail the path turns sharply to the west, and after a few steps the Solbeck site is revealed.

The house is surrounded on the south, west, and southeast by a steep dune that ascends quickly from the elevation of the house creating a feeling of enclosure and privacy (figures 1 and 2). At the southwest corner of the house seven concrete block steps extend partially up the dune. A trail beyond the steps leads to the highpoint of the dune where three wood benches are located, creating a small outdoor room that was further defined by a mature red oak and several cottonwood trees. The benches are oriented to provide sweeping views of the surrounding dunes and Lake Michigan to the northwest. Facing southwest views include sand dunes, a low valley, and some new large houses situated on the slopes of the sand dunes. To the north of the house, dense deciduous vegetation extends into a ravine that descends quickly from the elevation of the house. Directly northeast of the house a small level area provides a second outdoor room that contained a large picnic table. This area is surrounded by several mature deciduous trees and a small sand berm (to the east). It overlooked the ravine to the north and west. From the house site the sound of the waves on Lake Michigan and song birds is prevalent. The small outdoor rooms in the area of the picnic table and at the top of the dune exhibit a skillful use of the site. The outdoor rooms are well situated and in harmony with the natural surroundings.

Vegetation within and near the site consists of deciduous woodland vegetation including maples, red oaks, catalpa, and other trees, as well as various woody shrubs. There are several mature deciduous trees located on the east and northeast sides of the house as well as to the south on the top of the dune. The dune at the south side of the house is encroaching on the structure. The dune on the west side of the house appeared to be unstable and erosion threatens the structure. A historic photograph (ca. 1930), which showed nearby properties on Dabbert Drive, indicated that the overall setting has changed from one dominated by open expanses of bare sand dunes to one of vegetation covered dunes and patches of woodland. Given the sizes of the trees located near the site and in the ravine to the north it appears that the wooded character was vastly different from that of approximately thirty to forty years prior to 2010. It is likely that the surrounding area consists of more bare sand dunes, dune

grasses, and less woody vegetation historically. It is possible that views of Lake Michigan were once apparent from the house site.

The Solbeck site landscape retains historic features that convey its historic integrity including: the house; its location and relationship to the surrounding dunes, topography, vegetation, and Lake Michigan; the two outdoor rooms; the mature trees located near the house; and the symbiotic relationship between the house and the natural setting. The outdoor rooms and placement of the house reflected sensitively organized outdoor living areas. Views of Lake Michigan from the top of the dune, as well as the sounds of the waves from the house site, provided a connection between the lake and the site. All of these elements combined create a site that exhibits a unique and striking sense of place.

History:

Orville J. Hogue of Chicago platted the Lake Shore Addition to the New Stock Yards at Porter Beach in 1891; relatively early in the development of the Indiana Dunes. Hogue superimposed a grid of streets with twenty-five by one hundred foot lots over the rolling landscape of sand dunes. What is now Dabbert Drive was named Michigan Avenue, and the current Duneland Drive was 128th Street. Reportedly, Hogue's Lake Shore Addition to the New Stock Yards was designed to trick people into thinking they were buying land near the Chicago stockyards. Despite a flurry of real estate transactions there was little if any residential development at Porter Beach at the time. However, by the early 1900s the beach had become a popular location for bathing, despite a lack of amenities such as a bathhouse.

Significant residential development at Porter Beach followed the 1923 authorization of Indiana Dunes State Park; which is located just east of Porter Beach. When the Indiana Conservation Department began acquiring land for the state park many people who owned cottages on that land were forced to give them up and look for new locations. Anticipating this demand Valparaiso attorney Frank Parks purchased many lots in Porter Beach, and in 1923 he initiated a survey of the Lake Shore Addition. In 1925 the town of Porter annexed the Porter Beach area. In 1930 the Johnson Brothers built a thirty room hotel at Porter Beach, from then on known also as Johnson's Beach. The Johnson Brothers had operated a popular restaurant and fish house at Waverly Beach, within the new state park, and were required to relocate. The Johnson Brothers Inn, still extant, brought additional visitors and seasonal residents to Porter Beach.

The Solbeck site is located on lot twelve in block seven in the Lake Shore Addition to the New Stock Yards, part of a parcel comprised of lots ten through thirteen. On February 9, 1907, Elvina Hogue transferred lots ten through twenty-four, except lot nineteen, in block seven to May Buck,

beginning a complicated chain of real estate transactions involving what eventually became the Solbeck site. In 1910 Henry Hubbard transferred lots ten through fourteen in block seven to Guy Cockley. In 1911 Guy Cockley and wife transferred these five lots to Louis Faden. In June 1913 Guy Cockley and wife transferred the lots to Ditlef Hansen, who transferred them back to Bessie Cockley in August 1913. Guy Cockley and Cockley Realty Company were involved in numerous real estate transactions in the Lake Shore Addition in the 1910s and 1920s.

The tax card gives a 1929 construction date for the Solbeck house, which agrees with the ca 1930 construction date given in the records at Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore. Construction in the 1920s or 1930s is consistent with the structural evidence and the history of development at Porter Beach. John Solbeck acquired the house and property in the 1960s. According to Joan Solbeck, John's daughter, the house was built by a husband and wife who were engineers. They willed the house to a church, and John Solbeck bought it from the church. Before they bought this house the Solbecks rented a cabin in Indiana Dunes State Park. When the state park stopped renting cabins in the 1960s the Solbecks purchased the house in Porter Beach. In 1977 John Solbeck sold the property to Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore, retaining a Reservation of Use and Occupancy. Joan Solbeck continued to use the house as a seasonal vacation home until September of 2010 when the Reservation of Use and Occupancy expired.

- Sources: Field investigations, Brenda W. Williams, Quinn Evans Architects, and Eileen Starr, National Park Service, October 2002.
- Field investigations, Jane C. Busch, Quinn Evans Architects, and Eileen Starr, National Park Service, November 2002.
- Jane C. Busch, Historic Preservation Consultant; and Brenda W. Williams, Landscape Architect, Quinn Evans Architects, July 2003.
- Historian: Judith Collins, Historical Architect, Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore
- Project Information: The architectural documentation project was carried out in 2011 for the National Park Service under the direction of Charles Pipal, AIA, with the cooperation of Judith Collins, Historical Architect for the Indiana Dunes National Lakeshore, and the help of teaching assistant Erin Kennealy. The architectural drawings were completed by Patricia Baum, Sarah Biggers, Michelle Chircop, Elissa Del Bel Belluz, Elizabeth Fisher, Fleming Garner, Sarah Horton, Kerryann Kanch, and Dana Oliveri, with the text by Kris Hartzell. All students are in the Master's of Science in Historic Preservation Program at the School of the Art Institute in Chicago.

Illustrations:

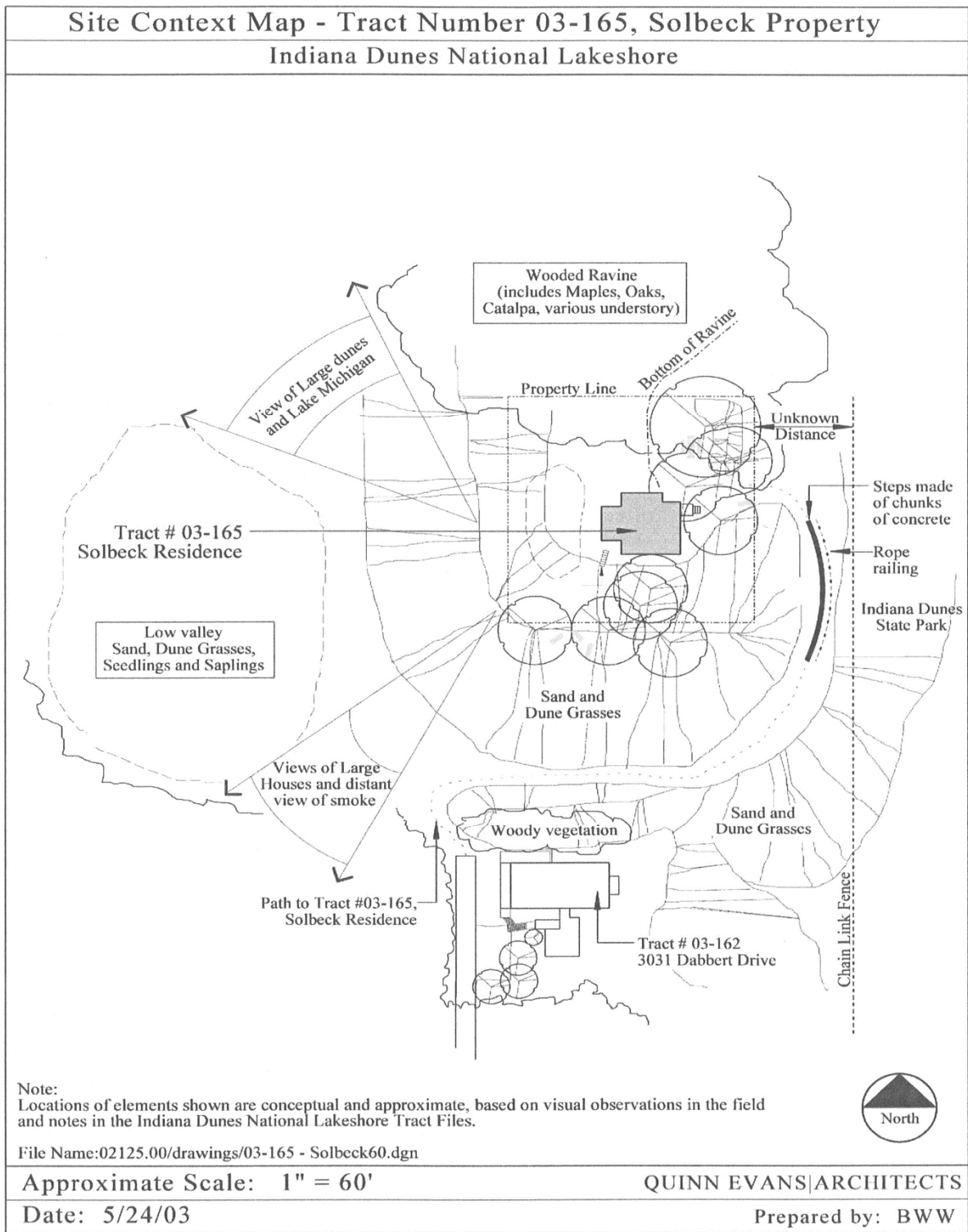


Figure 1

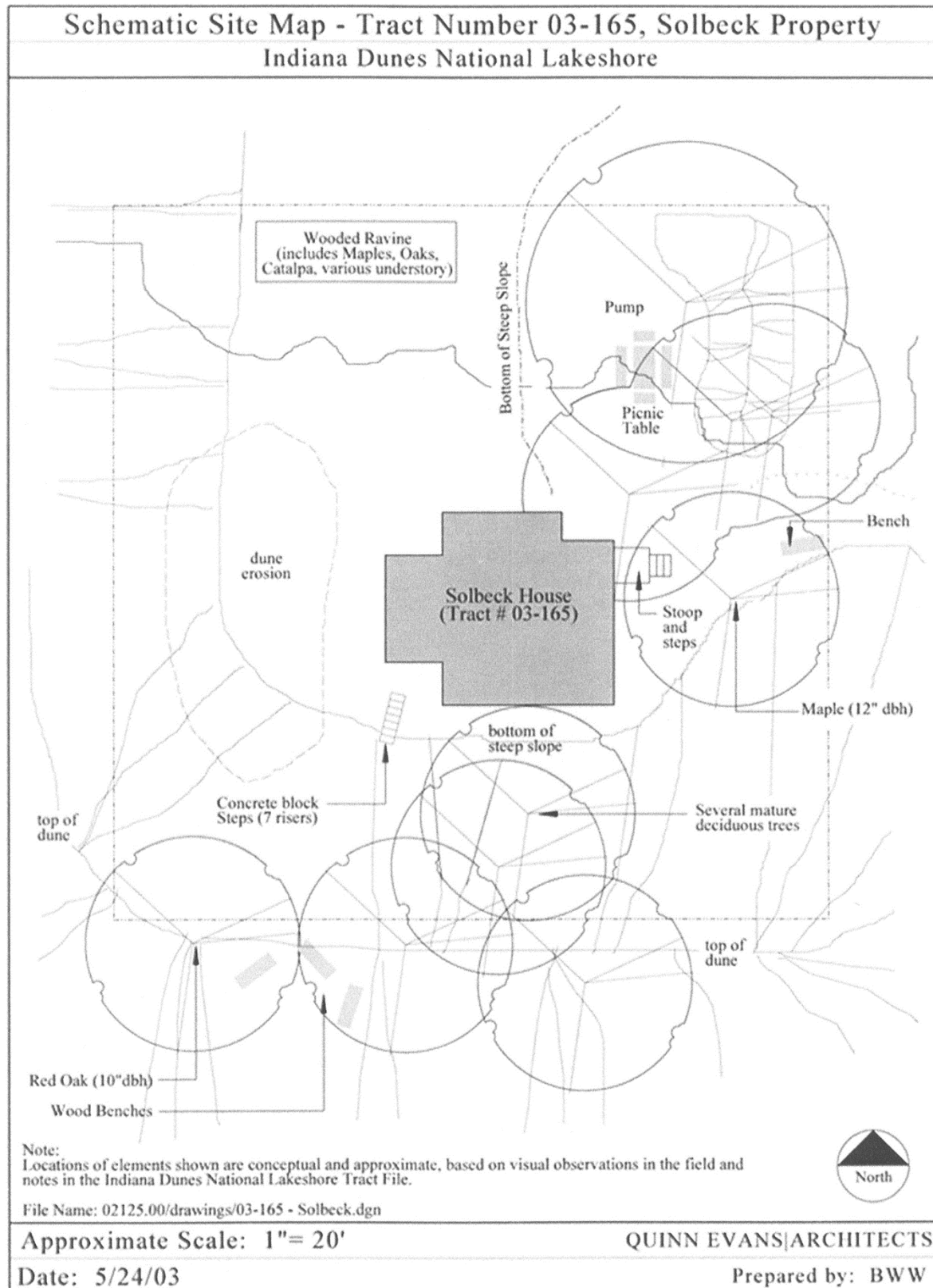


Figure 2



Figure 3: North and east facades. View from the northeast. November 2002
Photo by Eileen Starr, Historian, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 4: North and west facades. View from the northwest. November 2002
Photo by Eileen Starr, Historian, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 5: North and east facades. View from the northeast. May 2003
Photo by Brenda Williams, Landscape Architect, Quinn Evans Architects
Source: National Park Service



Figure 6: North elevation. May 2003
Photo by Brenda Williams, Landscape Architect, Quinn Evans Architects
Source: National Park Service



Figure 7: Main room, southwest view. August 2006
Photo by Tom Goldbin, R&VP, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 8: Main room, northeast view. August 2006
Photo by Tom Goldbin, R&VP, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 9: Kitchen, northwest view. August 2006
Photo by Tom Goldbin, R&VP, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 10: Northeast room (enclosed porch), northeast view. August 2006
Photo by Tom Goldbin, R&VP, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service



Figure 11: Northeast room (enclosed porch), northwest view. August 2006
Photo by Tom Goldbin, R&VP, National Park Service
Source: National Park Service